

ETS showdown stresses out aviation

送信者: POLITICO Pro Morning Mobility Europe 受信日時: 2026-07-17 14:03

【メール原文】

Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure. By TOMMASO LECCA with JORDYN DAHL and MARTINA SAPIO SNEAK PEEK — The aviation i

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SNEAK PEEK

— The aviation industry is awaiting a decision by the European Commission that is expected to end the exemption of long-haul flights from the ETS.

— The car lobby wants the Electrification Action Plan to include reduced taxes for EVs and charging stations.

— Lawmakers from across Europe are pressuring Denmark's Fayard shipyard to stop servicing Russia-linked LNG tankers.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility. Tips to jdahl@politico.eu , tlecca@politico.eu and msapio@politico.eu . Follow us @tommylecca , @jordyndahl and @martsapio

Mark your calendars: Our weekly mobility calendar landed in your inboxes on Thursday. You can also go online to export and plan your week or suggest your own event.

DRIVING THE DAY

AVIATION NERVOUS AHEAD OF COMMISSION VERDICT ON CARBON PRICING: The European Commission is expected to decide today on how to end the carbon pricing exemption for flights departing the EU for destinations outside Europe. Such a move could reignite tensions with the United States and China if their airlines are brought into the Emissions Trading System; Tommaso has more .

Lobbying kicks into gear: With DG CLIMA determined to press ahead with expanding the ETS to international aviation, airline groups are appealing to governments to oppose the proposal. Düsseldorf Airport CEO Lars Redeligx, who is the incoming president of German aviation lobby BDL, urged Berlin to "send a clear signal in Brussels now: no unilateral European action by extending the EU ETS to international flights."

Keep your word: "In its National Aviation Strategy, the government made a clear commitment to Germany as an aviation hub," Redeligx added in a statement shared with Morning Mobility. "That commitment must now also apply at the European level."

Follow the money: European airline lobby A4E rejects the argument that extending the ETS would accelerate aviation decarbonization. Airlines represented by A4E “paid €2.3 billion last year [in ETS],” said the lobby’s managing director, Ourania Georgoutsakou. “Where is that money, and why is it not being used to decarbonize aviation?” According to Georgoutsakou, airlines should instead have “the right to claim back all our ETS payments potentially in sustainable aviation fuels (SAF) allowances,” allowing carriers to invest directly in SAF rather than paying into the ETS.

Decisive moment: According to the InfluenceMap think tank, which monitors corporate lobbying, “the EU faces a decisive moment to steer aviation emissions in line with global emissions reduction targets.” Béatrice des Boscqs, the organization’s aviation senior analyst, told us that “alongside successfully limiting the EU ETS, the aviation industry continues to push its usual playbook of narratives to systematically oppose, weaken, or delay any stringent climate policy.”

Unsustainable: “This persistent pushback against stringent climate policies calls into question not only the credibility of the industry’s decarbonization goals but also its long-term sustainability,” des Boscqs added.

From air to sea: Maritime transport already falls under an expanded ETS, with large ships at EU ports required to pay ETS allowances covering 50 percent of emissions from voyages to or from ports outside the bloc. According to Stefano Messina, chairman of Italian shipping lobby Assarmatori, the maritime ETS offers “a clear example of what happens when a regional taxation scheme is applied to an international sector: It creates market distortions and damages the continent’s economy.”

The maritime ETS, Messina argued, is encouraging shipping companies to relocate transshipment — the transfer of containers from large vessels to smaller ships serving their final destinations — from European to non-EU ports. “This relocation, already underway in the Mediterranean, is not only about vessels. It is also about terminal investment and jobs,” he added.

CARS

CAR SECTOR LAYS OUT DEMANDS FOR ELECTRIFICATION ACTION PLAN: Car lobby ACEA and electric vehicle association e-Mobility Europe co-signed a letter to the Commission on Thursday presenting the industry’s demands for the Electrification Action Plan, which is expected later today. Topping the list are taxation changes that would make it cheaper and easier for both passenger cars and heavy-duty vehicles to charge.

What’s this about? The long-awaited EAP will set out how electricity should replace fossil fuels across transport, heating and industry. In a draft obtained by POLITICO, the proposal includes measures to promote the uptake of household batteries and EVs. It also promises to overhaul network charges to incentivize electric vehicles and introduce standards for the vehicle’s batteries to feed into the grid.

In line with industry demands: The joint letter touches on bi-directional charging, in which an EV can put energy back into the grid. Beyond creating standards for energy transfers, however, the two groups want the plan to introduce “market-based incentives that reward participation in flexibility technologies.”

All about taxes: The plan should ensure that electricity is taxed less than gas, the joint letter says. Batteries, zero-emissions vehicles and charging should also receive a 0 percent VAT tax “following the precedent set by solar panels.”

REPORT PAINTS BLEAK PICTURE OF AUTOMOTIVE EMPLOYMENT: The European Commission's proposed flexibilities on the CO2 emissions targets that automakers must reach in 2035 will result in the loss of 726,000 jobs by 2040, according to a new report from the Fraunhofer Institute for Industrial Engineering, commissioned by the Gesamtmetall employers' association.

A note on methodology: The report studied four scenarios for the automotive package and how many internal combustion engine vehicles or hybrids are allowed to be sold past 2035. It only studied employment in powertrain manufacturing and the installation of those components; employment across research, software, sales or other functions was not included.

By the numbers: According to the study, around 1.6 million people in Europe currently work on making powertrains (engines, transmissions, electric motors). Both the original de facto combustion engine ban and the Commission's revised proposal would result in the loss of 660,000 jobs by 2035. If the proposed targets shift toward what the industry and their conservative political backers want, that number drops to 560,000 lost jobs.

MARITIME

POLITICIANS TURN UP PRESSURE ON SHIPYARD OVER RUSSIAN LNG: More than 100 lawmakers from across Europe are urging Denmark's Fayard shipyard to stop servicing the specialized Arc7 tankers that keep Russia's Arctic LNG exports running. Campaigners had revealed earlier this month that the shipyard was preparing the vessels before new EU sanctions take effect.

The letter: In an open letter coordinated by Danish Green MEP Villy Søvndal, 101 parliamentarians — including 51 MEPs and 50 national and regional lawmakers from 16 countries — call on Fayard to refuse any further maintenance work on vessels serving Russia's Yamal LNG project, and to publicly commit not to accept additional Arc7 tankers this year.

Reminder: The Rudolf Samoylovich arrived at Fayard on June 30, the first of up to six Arc7 LNG carriers expected to undergo maintenance before an EU ban on servicing vessels linked to Russian LNG exports takes effect on Jan. 1, 2027. Campaigners argued at the time that repairing the ships now will extend their operational lifespans well beyond the sanctions deadline, allowing them to continue supporting Russia's LNG exports.

Martina has more .

Political pressure: The signatories — including three vice presidents of the European Parliament from six political groups — argue that servicing the vessels now will keep Russia's specialized LNG fleet operational for years after the sanctions take effect. "This is not only a commercial matter. It is a question of Europe's security, Denmark's credibility and solidarity with Ukraine," they write.

Fayard's position: The Danish shipyard previously told POLITICO that its work complies with current EU sanctions and maritime safety rules. It argued that it services internationally owned vessels operating legally under current EU rules, and that the work will cease once the new restrictions take effect.

TRUCKS

AUSTRIA DEALT BLOW IN ITALY TRUCK EMISSIONS CASE: Austrian measures to limit truck traffic on a key corridor through the Alps are against EU law, a top EU court adviser said Thursday, siding mostly with Italy (which had brought the action).

Context: The Brenner Pass is one of Europe's main north-south trade routes and is key to the EU economy, but for locals it's a source of pollution, noise and congestion. To limit traffic flows, Austria's Tyrol region has imposed several restrictions on transit trucks, including a ban on driving at night and on transporting certain goods. But those policies have led to blowback from Berlin and Rome, which say Austria infringed on their EU right to free movement.

No, grazie: Italy is now challenging four of the measures imposed by Tyrol before the Court of Justice of the European Union, our colleague Leonie Cater reports, targeting bans on nighttime, winter and sectoral traffic, as well as a system to limit access to a specific motorway. While Austria accepts that some of those measures restrict the free movement of goods, it argues they're justified due to "overriding reasons of general interest" — protecting the environment, human health and road safety.

Not quite: Advocate General Campos Sánchez-Bordona recommends that the court side with Italy on the three bans. On the sectoral traffic ban restricting trucks from transporting certain goods, for example, he suggests that Austria should have examined whether it could relax the ban once pollution levels on the relevant motorway sections meet EU air quality standards.

By the book: But Tyrol's system of "dosing" or limiting access to the Inn Valley motorway is in line with EU law, according to the court adviser. That's as long as Austria's representation of the system — that it amounts to a speed limit imposed on an exceptional basis, on certain sections of the motorway — is valid.

Caveat: While the advocate general's recommendations aren't binding on the top court, judges frequently follow them. A final judgment will be delivered at a later date.

PIT STOPS

A new report by the International Energy Agency shows that China is ramping up restrictions on critical resources, tripling the number of materials under export controls between December 2023 and April 2025.

THANKS TO: Leonie Cater.

Headlines

Here's a recap of yesterday's news, along with Pro articles and alerts from overnight.

EU sets up biggest climate fight of 2026 by slamming brakes on carbon market

Brussels wants to let industry pollute more and for longer. Parliament and member countries will have some thoughts on that.

By Ben Makuch · Jul 16, 2026, 09:00 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

The European Commission's moment of climate truth

Two policy announcements on Friday will show whether the Commission can keep its emissions-cutting promises.

By Zia Weise, Elena Giordano · Jul 16, 2026, 07:46 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

'Storm' looms for aviation as EU plans to price emissions from international flights

Brussels is worried that the U.S. and China might retaliate over extending the EU's Emissions Trading System to long-haul flights.

By Tommaso Lecca, Sara Schonhardt · Jul 16, 2026, 06:08 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

EU bets fossil fuel lobby is crying wolf over supply shock warnings

Oil and gas firms say EU methane rules will force them to stop exporting to Europe. The Commission thinks they're bluffing.

By Ben Munster · Jul 16, 2026, 03:23 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

EPP confirms position on weakening ETS

By Ben Makuch · Jul 16, 2026, 01:22 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

Commission yet to agree on key details of ETS review

By Ben Makuch · Jul 16, 2026, 12:50 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

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Discussions within the Council or its preparatory...

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